

India's First D2M Phone Aims To Redefine Mobile Reach

Lava and Tejas Networks are pioneering innovative new broadcast tech

Jayesh Shinde | editor@digit.in

When Lava and Tejas Networks unveiled India's first Direct-to-Mobile (D2M) feature phone, it wasn't just another budget phone – it was the start of a telecommunications revolution. With around half a billion Indians still on 2G or outside reliable data coverage, this phone enables access to live TV, educational programs, and emergency alerts—without using mobile data.

With over 400 million feature-phone users in rural and remote areas, D2M's impact could be massive. It uses UHF-band broadcast signals to deliver video, audio, and text directly to a built-in TV tuner chip—no internet needed. This isn't just an upgrade; it's a leap toward universal infotainment and emergency messaging.

Still wondering what D2M is? It's a broadcast system that delivers video and audio directly to mobile devices via airwaves—no internet or data plan needed. Currently under trial by India's DoT and Prasar Bharati, it's expected to roll out commercially in 2025.

For telecom providers like Airtel, BSNL, Jio, and Vi, D2M is a game-changer. By offloading data-heavy content from congested networks, it frees up valuable spectrum and lowers infrastructure costs—while giving users more value with less strain on their data plans. It's a rare win-win for both carriers and consumers.

At a press event in Mumbai, I sat down with Lava's Executive Director & Chief Manufacturing Officer Sanjeev Agarwal (SA) and Parag Naik (PN), co-founder of erstwhile Saankhya Labs and Executive Vice President, Tejas Networks' visionary co-founder to unpack the journey behind this breakthrough.

From Saankhya Labs' SL3000 radio chipset to MediaTek's MT6261 SoC, the collaboration blends Indian chip innovation with scalable manufacturing. They've packed digital broadcasting into a sub-250 MHz, 4MB RAM device—an engineering feat that surpasses bulkier global efforts.

As they explain in their own words, D2M isn't just about technology—it's about easing network congestion, bridging the digital divide, and pushing India from “assemble” to “invent.” Read on for the story behind this game-changing device and why it matters nationwide.

What inspired Lava to pursue India's first D2M path?

Sanjeev: As an Indian smartphone and electronics manufacturer with in-house design and R&D labs, Lava has been at the forefront of innovation, aligned with government initiatives at

both central and state levels, empowering the masses through digital innovations. The integration of D2M (Direct-to-Mobile) technology into feature phones marks a significant breakthrough, poised to transform content consumption. When Tejas developed the chip, our R&D team at Lava swiftly integrated it into our feature phones, reflecting our commitment to digital inclusion.

In India, digital connectivity is still out of reach for a substantial portion of the population, particularly in rural and remote areas where mobile internet is either unaffordable or unavailable. The D2M-enabled feature phone extends this reach by leveraging terrestrial broadcasting, enabling users to access live TV, educational content, and emergency alerts without relying on mobile data

or Wi-Fi. This innovation represents a transformative step towards accessible infotainment and public service communication, perfectly aligning with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a 'Digital India' and an 'Atmanirbhar Bharat' – a future where technological empowerment touches every citizen.

What were some of the challenges, breakthroughs, and differentiators versus global counterparts?

Parag: The development of this D2M-enabled feature phone stemmed



Sanjeev Agarwal
Executive Director & Chief
Manufacturing Officer,
Lava International Limited